Board 1
North Deals
None Vul

♠ 7 4
♥ A Q 8 6 2
♦ Q 6
♣ A 8 4 3

♠ A 9 2
♥ J 7 3
♦ A 9 2
♣ J 9 6 5

♠ K Q J 10
♥ 10 9
♦ 7 4 3
♣ K 10 7 2

♠ 8 6 5 3
♥ K 5 4
♦ K J 10 8 5
♣ Q

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1♥	Pass	3♥
Pass	4♥		
All Pass			

4♥ by North
Lead: ♠K

Some pretty agressive bidding gets you to a challenging game. North is to play 4♥. East leads the ♠K, overtaken by West's ♠A. West returns a ♠ to East's ♠10, and he then plays the ♠Q.

You ruff the third ♠.

East plays low.

West ducks.

Losers: ♠=2 ♥=0 ♦=1 ♣=3 Total = 6

With 2 tricks already gone you still have 4 losers. You could consider ruffing the 3 ♣ losers in dummy but that would just create a trump loser even when trumps are splitting 3-2. So it looks like you will have to establish the ♦ suit for discards. You could pull trumps and then play your ♦Q, hoping the defenders will grab their ♦A immediately. But unless they are real novices they will hold it up one round and you'll no longer be able to reach dummy.

The solution is to establish the ♦s before you use up dummy's ♥K.

Ruff the third ♠, then play ♦Q, (which they will duck), and another ♦, (which they will probably take). Win whatever they return, pull trumps ending in dummy, and enjoy your 3 ♦ winners.

If West does not take the second ♦ you continue the suit, and whether you ruff or discard a loser you still make the contract.

Board 2
South Deals
None Vul

	♠ Q J 9 ♥ K Q 10 5 4 ♦ 9 4 ♣ 8 6 3	
♠ K 10 8 6 ♥ 9 6 3 ♦ Q 7 2 ♣ J 9 2	N W E S	♠ 4 3 2 ♥ A 8 2 ♦ K J 5 ♣ Q 10 7 4
	♠ A 7 5 ♥ J 7 ♦ A 10 8 6 3 ♣ A K 5	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1NT
Pass	2♦	Pass	2♥
Pass	2NT	Pass	3NT
All Pass			

3NT by South
Lead: ♠6

North's 3♦ bid was a transfer to ♥s, and his 2NT bid showed exactly 5 ♥s with an invitational strength hand. South is to play 3NT. West leads the ♠6, you play dummy's ♠9 and East contributes the ♠2.

Winners: ♠=2 ♥=0 ♦=1 ♣=2 Total = 5

The math is easy - you need 4 ♥ tricks. And you should be able to manage that by driving out the ♥A. But the defenders will probably hold up one or two rounds when you play on ♥s, so you must have an outside entry to dummy.

The ♠ Q J will provide that entry **IF** you make sure to win the first trick with your ♠A as an unblocking move. If you don't do so then West will be able to keep you out of the dummy and away from those good ♥s.

Suppose you allow dummy's ♠9 to hold the first trick, then start on ♥s. East will hold up the ♥A for 1 or 2 rounds. When he does win it he will return a ♠ and whether you play the ♠A or a low ♠ West will be able to prevent you from reaching dummy.

But if you win the first trick with the ♠A, then dummy's ♠ Q J will provide a guaranteed entry to the good ♥s.

Board 3
East Deals
E-W Vul

	♠ A 10 5 ♥ 9 7 ♦ A K 6 3 ♣ A K 9 5	
♠ 8 6 3 ♥ A 8 2 ♦ Q J 9 ♣ J 10 7 4	N W E S	♠ Q 9 7 2 ♥ K 6 4 ♦ 10 8 2 ♣ Q 6 3
	♠ K J 4 ♥ Q J 10 5 3 ♦ 7 5 4 ♣ 8 2	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
		Pass	Pass
Pass	1♦	Pass	1♥
Pass	2NT	Pass	3NT
All Pass			

3NT by North
Lead: ♠2

North is to play 3NT. East leads the ♠2, you play dummy's ♠4 and West plays the ♠8.

Winners: ♠=3 ♥=0 ♦=2 ♣=2 Total = 7

Needing just two more winners it looks straightforward to establish dummy's ♥ suit. Suppose you win the ♠10 and play the ♥9. If the defenders win this trick you are home free. You win their ♠ return with your ♠A, then continue ♥s to drive out their last stopper while you still have the ♠K as a dummy entry.

This won't work against good defenders, who will hold up on the first ♥ trick and win the second. Then when they continue ♠s you won't have another ♥ to return to dummy, so while you can use the ♠K as an entry to establish the ♥s you will never get back to use the good ones.

Instead you should win the first trick with your ♠A. Now when you attack ♥s a defensive holdup won't hurt you because you have **TWO** ♠ entries, the ♠J by a finesse and the ♠K.

East is almost certain to hold the ♠Q because his ♠2 opening lead promises an honor and the ♠Q is the only one you don't have.

So the ♠ finesse is an odds-on play to get a second dummy entry.

Board 4
East Deals
None Vul

♠ Q J 8 2
♥ A 6 3
♦ Q 10 8
♣ 9 4 3

♠ 10 9 6
♥ Q 10 7 2
♦ 9 4 3
♣ K Q 8

♠ A K 7 5 4 3
♥ J 9 5
♦ —
♣ J 10 7 2

♠ —
♥ K 8 4
♦ A K J 7 6 5 2
♣ A 6 5

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
		2♠	Dbl
Pass	2NT	Pass	3♦
Pass	4♦	Pass	5♦
All Pass			

5♦ by South
Lead: ♠10

3NT would have been a lot easier, but you didn't get there. South is to play 5♦. West leads the ♠10.

East plays the ♠K and you ruff with the ♦2.

West plays low.

East shows out.

East covers with the ♠A.

Losers: ♠=0 ♥=1 ♦=0 ♣=2 Total = 3

The good news is that you only have one loser to get rid of. The bad news is that there doesn't seem to be a good place to put it.

Unlikely as it seems, your best candidate for establishment is dummy's ♠8. West is marked with 3 ♠s, and having led the ♠10 there is a good chance that he also has the ♠9. If so you can ruff it out.

Cover the ♠10 with dummy's ♠J, and when East plays one of his honors ruff in your hand. Play a trump to the ♦10, East showing out. Lead the ♠Q. East will be forced to play his other high honor, (if he doesn't you would discard a loser), and you ruff again.

Back to dummy with the ♦Q and ruff the ♠2 with a high trump just to be safe. West drops the ♠9 on this trick.

Pull West's last trump and enter dummy with the ♥A and **FINALLY** discard a loser on the now established ♠8.

When your only hope of making a contract is for the defender's cards to be a certain way, just assume that they lie perfectly for you and barge ahead.

Here you needed ♠ 10 9 x to be with West if you were to make the contract so you played for just that holding.

Board 5
South Deals
N-S Vul

	♠ A Q J 10 9 7 ♥ K 10 5 ♦ A 5 ♣ A K	
♠ 8 2 ♥ Q 8 2 ♦ Q 10 9 4 ♣ Q J 7 2		♠ 5 3 ♥ J 7 6 4 ♦ K J 7 3 2 ♣ 10 5
	♠ K 6 4 ♥ A 9 3 ♦ 8 6 ♣ 9 8 6 4 3	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			Pass
Pass	2♣	Pass	2NT
Pass	3♠	Pass	4♠
Pass	4NT[1]	Pass	5♦[2]
Pass	6♠		
All Pass			

1. Blackwood
2. 1 ace

6♠ by North
Lead: ♠5

North is to play 6♠. East leads the ♠5.

Losers: ♠=0 ♥=1 ♦=1 ♣=0 Total = 2

First pull trumps with the ♠A and ♠Q, both defenders following. Next you must establish dummy's ♣ suit to get rid of one of your losers. If the suit splits 3-3 that will be easy since you have two dummy entries, one to get there to ruff the third ♣ and the other to get there to enjoy playing the winners. But ♣s will probably split 4-2 so the two entries won't be enough. Here's how to make the defenders help you establish the suit.

After pulling trumps, play the ♣ A K, then ♦A.

You exit with a small ♦ and West wins.

The defender who won the ♦ trick has a problem. If he plays another ♦ you will get a ruff-sluff, and if he plays a ♥ you will play for the ♥Q and ♥J to be in different hands. So he will probably play a ♣.

You ruff in your hand, play a trump to dummy's ♠K and ruff the ♣8, establishing the ♣9 while you still have the ♥ entry.

Notice that this Plan would also succeed if the ♣s had split 3-3.

This was a combination of Suit Establishment and End-play. The lesson on Eliminations contains a lot more of this type of hand.